

DISTINCT CHARACTER

COGNITIVE ARCHITECTURE | NARRATIVE CONTROL SYSTEM

The Narrative Control System

NCS-1 COMPANION MATERIALS

Resource Companion | Integration Exercises | Quick Reference | Deepening Paths

Companion materials for NCS-1: Narrative Control System

Prerequisite: IOS-1 and MES-1 required

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Resource & Research Companion

A curated guide to the researchers, books, frameworks, and media that directly support your work inside NCS-1. Use these to deepen comprehension, not to replace doing the exercises.

How To Use This Section

Each resource is mapped to a specific module or concept within NCS-1. Engage with a resource when you encounter resistance or confusion in the corresponding module, or when you want to understand the theoretical basis behind a protocol you are already practicing.

Do not treat this as a reading list to complete before using the protocol. The protocol is the primary tool. These resources are support.

Researchers And Thinkers

Stephen Porges

Polyvagal Theory / Autonomic Nervous System Science

Core idea: The autonomic nervous system operates in a hierarchy of states: ventral vagal (safety), sympathetic (mobilization), and dorsal vagal (shutdown). Narrative interpretation is can be shaped by which state is active.

Why it matters for NCS-1: NCS-1 explicitly builds on the premise that neuroception precedes cognition. Porges explains why the nervous system is not a background variable. It is one regulating layer beneath many interpretive acts.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Neuroceptive Override. Module 9: Narrative Stability Under Pressure. Module 8:

Identity Standards Reset (Capacity-Adjusted Standards note).

When to engage: Before beginning Part IV if the Override Scripts are not activating effectively. When pressure events

consistently override your protocols.

Aaron Beck

Cognitive Behavioral Theory / Schema Therapy

Core idea: Automatic thoughts are generated by deeper cognitive schemas, belief structures formed through early experience. Behavioral change without schema-level work is surface correction.

Why it matters for NCS-1: The seven distortion types in Module 3 draw directly from Beck's taxonomy of cognitive distortions, with NCS-1 extending them into an identity-governance framework. Beck provides the theoretical foundation for why distortions are predictable rather than random.

Modules supported: Module 3: The Seven Distortion Types. Module 4: The Narrative Audit Matrix.

When to engage: When completing the Distortion Profile exercise and wanting to understand why specific distortion types

cluster the way they do.

Jeffrey Young

Schema Therapy

Core idea: Early maladaptive schemas are stable, self-reinforcing patterns developed in childhood that continue to generate distorted interpretation in adult life. They resist correction through ordinary behavioral effort.

Why it matters for NCS-1: Module 2's Narrative Archaeology directly maps to schema identification. Young's work clarifies what is being surfaced when you trace interpretive patterns to their origin authority.

Modules supported: Module 2: Narrative Archaeology. Exercise 2.1: Origin Tracing.

When to engage: When the Origin Tracing exercise surfaces early-life material that feels disproportionately charged or resistant to the Authority Revocation exercise.

Dan Siegel

Interpersonal Neurobiology / Narrative And The Brain

Core idea: The brain constructs coherent narrative from fragmented experience. A regulated nervous system is a prerequisite for narrative integration. Left-hemisphere narrative capacity and right-hemisphere somatic experience must be integrated for stable self-concept.

Why it matters for NCS-1: Siegel provides the neurological grounding for why biographical disruption (Module 10) requires structured integration rather than either suppression or uncontrolled processing.

Modules supported: Module 10: Biographical Disruption Integration. Module 9: Narrative Stability Under Pressure.

When to engage: When working through Module 10 on a significant disruption, particularly if the material activates strong somatic responses.

Lisa Feldman Barrett

Affective Neuroscience / Constructed Emotion Theory

Core idea: Emotions are not automatic reactions. They are constructed interpretations built by the brain using prediction, context, and learned categories. What you feel is partly determined by what you have been taught to expect.

Why it matters for NCS-1: Barrett's work supports the core premise of NCS-1: that interpretation is a constructed act, not a passive reception. This provides the scientific basis for why the Narrative Filter is governable rather than fixed.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Author Problem. Module 1: Surface the Operative Narrative.

When to engage: At the beginning of the protocol, if you encounter resistance to the premise that interpretation is constructed rather than received.

Bessel van der Kolk

Trauma And The Body / Somatic Experience

Core idea: Traumatic stress can be reflected through bodily activation patterns and reactivated through body-based cues before

conscious narrative processing is available. Talk-based approaches alone may be insufficient when body activation is driving interpretation.

Why it matters for NCS-1: Relevant to NCS-1 users who find that distortion patterns persist despite accurate cognitive identification. Van der Kolk's work supports why somatic regulation in Phase 1 may need to precede intensive narrative governance for some participants.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Neuroceptive Override. Part III: The Protection Architecture.

When to engage: When Override Scripts and cognitive tools are not producing results, and distortions appear to be somatically

rather than cognitively driven.

Michael White & David Epston

Narrative Therapy

Core idea: Problem-saturated stories are externalized and the person is positioned as separate from the problem.

Alternative stories that better represent lived experience can be co-authored and installed.

Why it matters for NCS-1: Narrative therapy provides the clinical tradition closest to NCS-1's architecture. The distinction between the person and the narrative, the externalization of the problem, and the deliberate authoring of an alternative account are all present in NCS-1's framework.

Modules supported: Module 2: Narrative Archaeology. Module 10: Biographical Disruption Integration. Closing: The Narrative

Authority Declaration.

When to engage: When working with a licensed provider who uses narrative therapy approaches. Provides a common

language for the clinical supplement in Part VI.

Books

The Body Keeps the Score

by Bessel van der Kolk

Core idea: How trauma is encoded in the body and why somatic regulation is a prerequisite for cognitive and narrative work.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Neuroceptive Override. Part I: The Narrative Map.

When to read: If Phase 1 work is incomplete or if distortion patterns appear resistant to cognitive tools alone.

Cognitive Therapy of Depression

by Aaron T. Beck

Core idea: The foundational text for cognitive distortion identification and correction. The source text for much of what NCS-1 builds upon and extends.

Modules supported: Module 3: The Seven Distortion Types. Module 4: The Narrative Audit Matrix.

When to read: For participants who want to understand the academic basis of the distortion taxonomy before working through the personal distortion profile.

How Emotions Are Made

by Lisa Feldman Barrett

Core idea: Emotions as constructed predictions rather than hardwired reactions. The brain builds emotional experience from past learning and current context.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Author Problem. The Control Loop.

When to read: When the concept of constructed interpretation (rather than received meaning) requires grounding in current neuroscience.

Mindsight

by Dan Siegel

Core idea: The neuroscience of self-awareness, interpersonal connection, and narrative integration. Explains how coherent autobiographical narrative supports psychological stability.

Modules supported: Module 10: Biographical Disruption Integration. Module 11: Standing Governance.

When to read: After completing Part V, if the biographical disruption integration work requires additional grounding in brain-based explanation.

Reinventing Your Life

by Jeffrey E. Young and Janet S. Klosko

Core idea: Accessible introduction to early maladaptive schemas, their origins, and their correction. The clinical companion to origin tracing work.

Modules supported: Module 2: Narrative Archaeology. Exercise 2.1 and 2.2.

When to read: When the Authority Revocation exercise produces resistance or incomplete results.

The Polyvagal Theory in Therapy

by Deb Dana

Core idea: Practical application of Porges' Polyvagal Theory. Explains how to identify nervous system states and use that awareness to support cognitive and relational functioning.

Modules supported: Module 9: Narrative Stability Under Pressure. Module 8: Capacity-Adjusted Standards.

When to read: When Override Scripts are failing under pressure and the cause appears to be nervous system state rather than cognitive misapplication.

Maps of Meaning

by Jordan B. Peterson

Core idea: How human beings construct meaning from experience through narrative structures. The role of mythological and psychological frameworks in organizing identity.

Modules supported: Introduction: The Author Problem. Module 2: Narrative Archaeology.

When to read: For participants who want deeper philosophical grounding in why narrative construction is a fundamental cognitive operation.

Research Domains And Key Articles

Domain	Source	Core Contribution	Module Supported
Cognitive Appraisal Theory	Lazarus & Folkman (1984)	Stress response is shaped by how events are appraised. This supports the Control Loop framework in NCS-1.	Introduction: The Control Loop. Module 4: Narrative Audit Matrix.
Narrative Identity Research	Dan McAdams	Identity is partly constructed through the stories people use to organize their lives and interpret experience.	Module 1: Surface the Operative Narrative. Module 10: Biographical Disruption Integration.
Self-Discrepancy Theory	E. Tory Higgins (1987)	The gap between actual self, ideal self, and ought self can generate specific emotional consequences.	Module 8: Identity Standards Reset.
Allostatic Load Research	McEwen & Stellar (1993)	Chronic stress carries cumulative physiological cost and supports the need for capacity-adjusted standards.	Module 8: Capacity-Adjusted Standards. Module 9: Narrative Stability Under Pressure.
Polyvagal Theory	Stephen Porges (1994, 2001)	An influential model of autonomic response patterns and their relationship to social engagement, cognitive functioning, and interpretation.	Introduction: Neuroceptive Override. Pressure-related protocols.

Podcasts And Audio Resources

Huberman Lab

Host: Andrew Huberman

Episodes on stress physiology, nervous system regulation, and cognitive performance. Relevant episodes: stress inoculation, neuroplasticity, deliberate cold exposure (for nervous system training, not as a coping intervention).

Relevant to: Phase 1 foundation. Module 9 pressure preparation.

The Polyvagal Podcast

Host: Deb Dana

Practical application of Polyvagal Theory for practitioners and clinicians. Episodes address state identification, co-regulation, and the relationship between nervous system state and cognitive function.

Relevant to: Introduction: Neuroceptive Override. All somatic-adjacent modules.

Being Well Podcast

Host: Rick and Forrest Hanson

Neuroscience-informed psychology accessible to non-clinical participants. Episodes on cognitive schemas, self-compassion as a structural tool, and the neuroscience of self-concept.

Relevant to: Module 3 distortion types. Module 8 standards reset.

The Knowledge Project

Host: Shane Parrish

Mental models, decision architecture, and the structure of high-performance cognition. Relevant to the governance and systems framing of NCS-1.

Relevant to: Module 4: Narrative Audit Matrix. Module 11: Standing Governance.

Foundational Concepts Map

Neuroception A term used in Polyvagal Theory for subconscious threat and safety detection. It can operate below conscious awareness and shape interpretive context before deliberate narrative processing begins.

Protocol location: Introduction. Module 9.

Cognitive Schema Stable, self-reinforcing belief structures formed through early experience that generate automatic interpretations across situations (Beck, Young).

Protocol location: Module 2. Module 3. Module 8.

Narrative Identity The psychological theory that the self is constituted through story: the ongoing internal narrative that organizes experience into a coherent autobiographical account (McAdams, Ricoeur).

Protocol location: Module 1. Module 10. Closing.

Appraisal The cognitive evaluation of an event that determines its emotional and behavioral consequences. The site at which NCS-1 intervenes.

Protocol location: Introduction: Control Loop.

Allostatic Load The cumulative physiological cost of chronic stress. Relevant to understanding why capacity-adjusted standards are a structural necessity, not a lowered bar.

Protocol location: Module 8. Module 9.

Externalization The narrative therapy technique of positioning the problem as separate from the person. Foundational to the Non-Absorption Protocol.

Protocol location: Module 5. Module 6.

Interoception The perception of internal body states. Relevant to detecting the somatic signatures of distortion types before cognitive identification occurs.

Protocol location: Module 3 somatic signatures. Module 9.

Integration Exercises

These exercises extend the protocol into daily life. They are not replacements for the protocol exercises.

They are operational companions: tools for embedding the Narrative Control System into actual interpretive practice between formal sessions.

Before you begin Each exercise specifies which module it supports and a low-capacity adaptation for high-fatigue or high-load days.

The full version and the low-capacity version accomplish the same governance function. Use whichever version your current state supports.

Chronic illness note: these exercises are designed to function in abbreviated form. A two-minute version of most exercises is noted where relevant. Doing a shortened version consistently produces better installation than doing the full version intermittently.

Interpretation Audit: End-of-Day Scan

Type: Daily Reflection Protocol location: Module 1: Surface the Operative Narrative. Module 4: The Narrative Audit Matrix.

At the end of each day, identify three events that generated an automatic interpretation. For each, write one sentence: the event (observable facts only), and the meaning that arrived automatically. Do not correct the interpretations. Just surface them. The surfacing itself is the practice.

Reflection prompts:

- What event today produced the strongest automatic meaning?
- Was the meaning I assigned about me or about conditions?
- Did I apply a distortion type I can name? Which one?
- What would the accurate condition-level account of this event be?

Low-capacity adaptation

One event only. One sentence: what happened, and what it meant automatically. No correction required.

Distortion Type Spotter

Type: Behavioral Observation Protocol location: Module 3: The Seven Distortion Types.

For one week, track distortion types in real time rather than in retrospect. Keep a simple log: time, distortion type, context. No correction necessary during the tracking week. The goal is to build recognition speed, not to prevent distortions from occurring. Recognition precedes intervention.

Reflection prompts:

- Which distortion type appeared most today?
- In what context was it most active?
- Was there a somatic signal before I named it cognitively?
- Did the distortion compound into behavior before I caught it, or was I able to delay?

Low-capacity adaptation

Note one distortion per day, whatever type was most prominent. No analysis required.

Override Script Rehearsal

Type: Implementation Experiment Protocol location: Module 7: The Override Script Library.

Select your primary Override Script from Module 7. Once per day, in a low-stakes moment, apply it to a minor interpretive event, not a high-pressure situation. The goal is to install the script at a neurological level through repetition in ordinary conditions, so it is accessible under pressure when deliberate processing is reduced.

Reflection prompts:

- Did the script activate at the speed required today?
- Does the language still feel like mine, or has it become mechanical?
- What specific word or phrase in the script is doing the most work?
- Did the override redirect the interpretation, or did I agree with the script intellectually while the original interpretation remained operative?

Low-capacity adaptation

Read your primary script once. That is sufficient to maintain the installation on high-fatigue days.

Identity Boundary Check-In

Type: Tracking Prompt Protocol location: Module 5: The Identity Boundary Model. Module 6: The Non-Absorption Protocol.

Once per week, review the events of the preceding seven days. For each event that produced a negative interpretation, apply the Three-Question Protocol retrospectively: was it about me or conditions? A pattern or an instance? Accurate source information? Reclassify any events that were absorbed into identity but should have been externalized.

Reflection prompts:

- What did I absorb into identity this week that should have been externalized?
- What feedback or outcome am I still processing at an identity level?
- Apply Question 2: was there a confirmed pattern here, or a single instance I treated as evidence?
- Apply Question 3: was the source positioned to carry accurate information about me?

Low-capacity adaptation

One question only: what is still sitting in identity that belongs at the condition level?

Narrative Archaeology: Single Origin Trace

Type: Journaling Exercise Protocol location: Module 2: Narrative Archaeology. Exercise 2.1.

Select one automatic interpretation from the past week that felt disproportionately charged relative to the triggering event. Trace it: where did this interpretation come from? Who carried the authority that installed it? What conditions was it designed to navigate? Does that context still apply? This is not a trauma processing exercise. It is an administrative audit of an inherited interpretive standard.

Reflection prompts:

- What is the earliest version of this interpretation I can locate?
- Who or what gave this interpretation its authority?
- What did this interpretation help me navigate at the time of installation?
- Is the original context still active, or am I applying an old filter to a current situation?

Low-capacity adaptation

Name the interpretation and name the authority that installed it. Two sentences maximum.

Pressure Protocol Pre-Deployment

Type: Implementation Experiment Protocol location: Module 9: Narrative Stability Under Pressure. Exercise 9.1.

Before any anticipated high-pressure event (a difficult conversation, a performance context, a review, a period of heightened workload), complete a pre-deployment sequence: identify the distortion type most likely to activate, select the corresponding Override Script, and write one sentence confirming that identity assignment is temporarily suspended during the event. This preparation installs the protocol before it is needed.

Reflection prompts:

- What high-pressure condition am I about to enter?
- Which distortion type is most likely to activate in this context?
- What is my pre-deployed Override Script?
- What is the condition-level account of the worst plausible outcome in this situation?

Low-capacity adaptation

One sentence before the event: 'Identity assignment is suspended. I will process meaning after this event, not during it.' Standards Calibration Review

Type: Periodic Review Protocol location: Module 8: The Identity Standards Reset.

Monthly, review the identity standards you reset in Module 8. Standards can drift back toward their original inherited versions under accumulated pressure, often without notice. Check: is the reset standard still the operative version? Or has the inherited standard re-established itself? If drift has occurred, conduct a targeted reinstallation using the reset criteria: accurate, executable, mine.

Reflection prompts:

- Is my current operative identity standard still the reset version, or has the inherited version returned?
- What evidence in the past month suggests which version is actually running?
- Under what conditions did the inherited standard re-activate?
- What is one concrete action that reinstalls the reset standard?

Low-capacity adaptation

Read your reset standards from Module 8. Confirm they are still the operative versions. No analysis required if they are holding.

Biographical Disruption Status Check

Type: Periodic Reflection Protocol location: Module 10: Biographical Disruption Integration.

Monthly, revisit any disruption currently in the integration process. Assess current processing level: is the disruption still generating identity-collapse language, or has it moved to condition-level processing? Which stage of the integration protocol is active? Is the forward trajectory statement still accurate?

Reflection prompts:

- Is this disruption producing identity-level or condition-level interpretation currently?
- Has the language I use to describe this disruption changed since the initial integration work?
- Is the forward trajectory statement I wrote still accurate, or does it need updating?
- What distortion type is still most active in relation to this disruption?

Low-capacity adaptation

Read the forward trajectory statement you wrote in Stage 4 of the Integration Protocol. Notice whether it still feels accurate or whether the language has shifted.

Environmental Mapping: Narrative Trigger Audit

Type: Environmental Mapping Exercise Protocol location: Module 9: Pressure Condition Mapping. Module 5: Identity Boundary Model.

Map the environments and contexts in your regular life according to their distortion activation pattern. Which settings, relationships, or recurring situations consistently activate which distortion types? This is not about avoiding these environments. It is about entering them with pre-deployed infrastructure rather than unprepared.

Reflection prompts:

- Which physical or relational environments consistently activate Identity Collapse (Type I)?
- Which contexts produce Personalization Error (Type IV) most reliably?
- Are there environments where your Identity Boundary holds consistently? What is different about those contexts?
- For each high-activation environment, what is the pre-deployment protocol?

Low-capacity adaptation

Name one environment and one distortion type it reliably activates. Identify one Override Script for that pairing.

Weekly Governance Consolidation

Type: Weekly Review Protocol location: Module 11: Standing Governance Practices.

At the end of each week, spend ten to fifteen minutes answering five questions. This replaces the four-week structured audit with a standing protocol that does not require the protocol to be open.

Reflection prompts:

- What event this week generated the strongest automatic interpretation?
- What distortion type was operating, and what Override Script was applied or should have been?

- What did I absorb into identity this week that should have remained at the condition level?
- Is the self-concept I am currently operating from consistent with the identity architecture installed in IOS-1?
- What is one interpretive adjustment I am making before closing this week?

Low-capacity adaptation

Answer only the first and last question. Two minutes maximum.

Quick Reference Guide

Designed for high-fatigue, high-load, or cognitively overloaded states. This section does not require reading the protocol. It is the portable version of the protocol.

Core Distinctions

Identity level vs. condition level Identity-level interpretation: this event reveals something permanent and characteristic about who I am.

Condition-level interpretation: this event describes what occurred under specific circumstances. NCS-1 intervenes at the point where condition-level events are incorrectly assigned to identity.

Override Script vs. reframe A reframe attempts to make a negative interpretation feel positive. An Override Script replaces an inaccurate interpretation with an accurate one. Accuracy is the goal, not comfort.

Pattern vs. instance A single negative outcome is an instance. It carries no identity-level evidential weight. A pattern requires multiple independent occurrences across different contexts over time. Apply identity implications only to confirmed patterns.

Resetting a standard vs. lowering it Lowering a standard: accepting less than is achievable. Resetting a standard: replacing an inherited standard with one that is accurate, executable under actual conditions, and genuinely chosen.

Narrative Drift vs. identity update Narrative Drift: the gradual, unnoticed erosion of the installed identity under accumulated interpretive pressure.

Identity update: a deliberate, evidence-based revision of specific self-concept elements. Drift is passive. An update is governed.

Non-Absorption vs. avoidance Non-Absorption: classifying incoming experience at the condition level rather than absorbing it into identity. The event is still processed. Practical consequences are still addressed. Feedback value is still extracted. Avoidance:

not processing the event at all.

Key Reminders

- Regulation precedes correction. If the nervous system is dysregulated, the Override Scripts will not activate effectively. Check the body before attempting cognitive governance.
- Override Scripts work through consistent application, not intellectual agreement. Reading a script and agreeing with its logic is the first step. Installation requires repeated use at the moment of distortion.
- Biology first. Masking second. Meaning third. This is the sequence. Attempting narrative governance without the somatic foundation produces partial results.
- The Narrative Audit Matrix is a protocol, not a journaling exercise. Complete the columns in sequence.

Never skip the Evidence column.

- Identity assignment under pressure is almost always distorted. Delay interpretation during high-pressure events until sufficient processing capacity is available.
- The Quarterly Review is the primary protection against Narrative Drift. Weekly audits catch individual distortions. The quarterly review catches the accumulated pattern those distortions are creating.
- Narrative Archaeology does not complete the work. It makes the work possible by relocating inherited interpretations from the category of truth to the category of installed interpretation.
- The Authority Revocation is an administrative act, not a forgiveness exercise. The source no longer holds interpretive authority over current conditions. State it precisely.

Warning Signs

Warning: Override Scripts are not activating under pressure

Response: Check nervous system state first. Scripts require processing capacity. If the body is in sympathetic activation or dorsal freeze, the script will not fire. Return to Phase 1 regulation before attempting narrative override.

Warning: The same distortion type is appearing consistently across all contexts

Response: This indicates a schema-level pattern rather than situational interpretation. Module 2's Narrative Archaeology work may need revisiting. Consider whether clinical support would deepen the origin tracing.

Warning: Agreeing with the Override Script cognitively but the distortion remains operative

Response: Intellectual agreement is not installation. The script needs to be applied at the moment of distortion, not reviewed after the distortion has already compounded into behavior. Return to Exercise 7.2 and increase tracking frequency.

Warning: Identity standards drift back to inherited versions within days of a reset

Response: The inherited standard is receiving ongoing reinforcement from the environment (relationships, platform exposure, professional comparisons). Identify the source of reinforcement and limit it during the reinstallation period.

Warning: Narrative Drift has occurred without noticing it

Response: This is the normal failure mode. It is invisible in individual instances. Conduct the Quarterly Review immediately. Compare current operative self-concept to the identity architecture in IOS-1. Identify departure points and conduct targeted reinstallation for each.

Warning: Biographical disruption material is re-activating at identity-collapse level

Response: The integration work in Module 10 may not be complete. Identify which stage (Acknowledgment, Distortion Extraction, Narrative Placement, Forward Positioning) is producing resistance and work that stage specifically. Clinical support is appropriate here.

Common Mistakes

Skipping the Evidence column in the Narrative Audit Matrix The Evidence column is where distortions are detected. Without it, the Alternative Meaning column is speculation.

Treating Override Scripts as affirmations Affirmations assert a preferred self-concept. Override Scripts correct an inaccurate interpretive operation. The goal is accuracy, not positivity.

Applying the wrong Override Script to the wrong distortion type Each script targets a specific logical error. A script for Identity Collapse does not correct Scope Globalization.

Read all seven distortion types before completing the Personal Distortion Profile.

Attempting NCS-1 without completing IOS-1 and MES-1 NCS-1 builds directly on the Narrative Filter Audit from IOS-1 Module 4 and the identity architecture installed in that protocol. Partial prerequisites produce partial results.

Using the Biographical Disruption Integration protocol on events that are still in the acute phase The integration protocol addresses the meaning-making stage that follows stabilization. It is not a crisis protocol and should not be applied while the disruption is still in active progression.

Treating the Non-Absorption Protocol as a tool for avoiding accountability The Identity Boundary separates condition reports from identity verdicts. It does not eliminate accountability.

Accurate accountability requires a defined boundary: without one, accurate feedback and inaccurate feedback are absorbed indiscriminately.

Skipping the Quarterly Review Individual weekly audits detect distortions. The quarterly review detects the drift pattern that those distortions, over time, are producing. They are not interchangeable.

Troubleshooting Prompts

Situation: The protocol feels mechanical and is not producing real-time governance.

Protocol response: Personalize the Override Scripts again. A script that does not sound like your internal voice will not fire at the required speed. Return to Exercise 7.1 and rewrite the scripts in your current language.

Situation: I cannot identify which distortion type is active.

Protocol response: Return to Module 3 and read the somatic signatures section. Body detection can be faster than cognitive classification. Identify the physical sensation first, then name the distortion type.

Situation: I am applying the protocol correctly but the original distortion interpretation is still the operative one.

Protocol response: Frequency of application is insufficient. The installed interpretation requires more repetitions than the inherited interpretation to achieve operative status. Increase the tracking frequency in Exercise 7.2.

Situation: The Pressure Protocol is not accessible during actual pressure events.

Protocol response: Pre-deployment is the solution. Complete Exercise 9.1 in advance for every anticipated high-pressure condition. The protocol is a preparation tool, not a real-time decision tool.

Situation: Origin Tracing is producing material I cannot process alone.

Protocol response: This is appropriate for clinical support. Part VI (the Therapeutic Addendum) is designed for this purpose. Share the relevant modules with a licensed provider.

Low-Energy Deployment Guide

Minimum viable governance on high-fatigue days

These are the three actions that maintain the Narrative Control System on days when full protocol execution is not possible. Do not skip all three. Do at least one.

1. Read your primary Override Script

One script. Thirty seconds. This maintains the installation and keeps the governed interpretation accessible even if it is not actively deployed.

2. Apply the Three-Question Protocol to one event

One event from today. Three questions. Two minutes maximum. You do not need to correct the interpretation.

Name it correctly.

3. Confirm your Identity Boundary on one absorbed item

Identify one thing from today that you assigned to identity. Ask: is this about me, or about conditions? That single question is sufficient governance for a low-capacity day.

The Seven Distortion Types: Quick Reference

Type	Name	Error Structure	Override Direction
Type I	Identity Collapse	Event treated as identity verdict	An execution mismatch occurred in this context.
Type II	Permanence Assignment	Temporary condition given permanent status	This is the current condition. Current conditions are subject to change.
Type III	Scope Globalization	Specific pattern applied globally	This is true in this specific context. Its applicability elsewhere is unestablished.
Type IV	Personalization Error	External events attributed primarily to self	Name all relevant causal factors before assigning personal causation.
Type V	Authority Transference	Inherited evaluative standard applied as neutral	Identify the authority. Apply my own evaluative standard instead.
Type VI	Evidence Inversion	Contradicting evidence treated as confirmation	Contradicting evidence requires explanation, not dismissal.
Type VII	Narrative Drift	Gradual unnoticed departure from installed identity	Compare current self-concept to IOS-1 architecture. Identify departure points.

The Three-Question Classification Protocol

Question	Classification Prompt	Governance Rule
Question 1	Is this about me specifically, or about conditions?	If a more accurate explanation exists at the condition level, begin there.
Question 2	Is this a pattern or an instance?	Assign identity implications only to confirmed patterns across multiple independent contexts.
Question 3	Is the source of this feedback carrying accurate information about me?	Determine whether the source is positioned to carry accurate information before incorporating feedback into identity.

Optional Deepening Paths

These are directions for participants who have completed the core protocol and want to extend their understanding of the systems underlying the Narrative Control System. None of these are required. All of them support deeper implementation.

Engage with these after completing the core protocol exercises, not before. Deepening paths are most useful when you have operational experience with the protocol and are encountering specific resistance or curiosity that additional context would address.

Deepening Path 1: The Neuroscience of Interpretation

If the premise that interpretation is constructed rather than received requires more scientific grounding, this path provides it. The primary sources are Lisa Feldman Barrett's affective neuroscience research and Dan Siegel's interpersonal neurobiology framework.

Resources in this path:

- Barrett: How Emotions Are Made (full text)
- Siegel: The Developing Mind (for the neuroscience of narrative construction)
- Porges: The Polyvagal Theory (primary source text, technical)
- Huberman Lab: episodes on neuroplasticity and the predictive brain

When to engage: When the Override Scripts are not producing results and you need to understand why the body-based interpretation can precede cognitive correction.

Important

Do not treat this path as prerequisite material. The protocol is designed to function without this depth. Engage here if the neuroscience supports your practice, not as a way to delay doing the exercises.

Deepening Path 2: Schema and Origin Work

Module 2's Narrative Archaeology is an accelerated version of what schema therapy addresses over extended clinical engagement. If the origin tracing exercises produce material that feels persistently charged or that does not respond to Authority Revocation, this path provides the clinical framework for understanding why.

Resources in this path:

- Young and Klosko: Reinventing Your Life (accessible clinical text)
- Young, Klosko, and Weishaar: Schema Therapy (clinical reference text)
- Beck: Cognitive Therapy of Depression (foundational distortion taxonomy)
- Consideration: short-term schema-focused therapy with a licensed provider

When to engage: When Module 2 work surfaces early-life material that is resisting the governance tools, or when distortion patterns are persistent across all contexts regardless of override application.

Important

Schema-level work at depth is clinical work. This deepening path points toward appropriate professional support, not toward self-directed intensification of the archaeology exercises.

Deepening Path 3: Narrative Identity and Autobiography

The philosophical and psychological literature on how identity is constituted through narrative. This deepening path supports the Biographical Disruption Integration work and the Narrative Authority Declaration.

Resources in this path:

- McAdams: The Stories We Live By
- Ricoeur: Oneself as Another (philosophical, demanding)
- Epston and White: Narrative Means to Therapeutic Ends
- Bruner: Actual Minds, Possible Worlds

When to engage: After completing Module 10, particularly if the Forward Positioning statement feels difficult to write and additional conceptual grounding in narrative identity would support the work.

Important

This is philosophical and theoretical territory. Engage here if conceptual depth supports your practice. Do not substitute reading for doing the integration exercises.

Deepening Path 4: Chronic Illness and Capacity Governance

The identity standards work in Module 8 and the pressure protocols in Module 9 have specific relevance for participants managing chronic illness. This path provides additional frameworks for understanding the relationship between physiological capacity, identity standards, and narrative distortion.

Resources in this path:

- Toni Bernhard: How to Be Sick (practical narrative reframing under chronic conditions)
- Porges and Dana: Clinical Applications of Polyvagal Theory (for understanding the nervous system dimension of fatigue and capacity)
- Research domain: Illness narratives and identity disruption (academic literature on biographical disruption under chronic illness)
- Consideration: body-based regulation practices that support ventral vagal access as a prerequisite for narrative governance under chronic conditions

When to engage: When chronic illness is producing recurring identity-collapse interpretations that are not responding to the standard Override Scripts, or when capacity-adjusted standards are difficult to install due to ongoing identity pressure around reduced functioning.

Important

This is not a substitute for medical care or appropriate clinical support. The NCS-1 system supports psychological governance of the narrative dimension of illness experience. It does not address the physiological dimension.

Deepening Path 5: Governance Systems and Behavioral Architecture

NCS-1 is a governance protocol. If the systems-thinking dimension of the framework resonates and you want to understand the broader behavioral architecture tradition it draws from, this path provides that context.

Resources in this path:

- Kahneman: Thinking, Fast and Slow (the dual-process model underlying the gap between automatic

interpretation and deliberate override)

- Clear: Atomic Habits (behavioral installation mechanics, relevant to Override Script repetition requirements)
- Parrish: The Great Mental Models series (decision architecture and interpretive frameworks)
- Cialdini: Influence (for understanding how external authorities install interpretive standards)

When to engage: When the behavioral installation dimension of the Override Script work is not producing results and understanding the mechanics of habit formation would support more consistent application.

Important

These resources address behavioral architecture broadly. Apply them specifically to the NCS-1 installation work rather than treating them as general productivity frameworks.

A note on sequence

The companion materials in this guide are most effective when the core protocol is the primary tool. Resource engagement, integration exercises, and deepening paths are support structures. They extend and deepen what the protocol installs. They do not replace it.

The Narrative Control System is installed through doing the exercises, not through understanding the theory. Theory without application produces comprehension. Application produces governance.

End of NCS-1 Companion Materials